



The Real Cost of What We Throw Away

How the food we waste harms people, the planet, and the living things around us.

The Issue

Topic: food waste. **The problem:** about a third of all the food grown for people is never eaten. In the U.S., close to 30 to 40 percent of the food supply is thrown out, most of it from our own homes, plus farms, stores, and restaurants. Food waste is a sustainability problem because it hits all **three E's** at once.



Economy

Billions of dollars and resources are thrown away.



Environment

Wasted food drives emissions and uses up land and water.



Equity

Food is trashed while many people go hungry.



Why It Matters: The Impacts



On People

- **Higher costs.** Wasted food costs the average U.S. family of four about \$1,500 a year.
- **Hunger nearby.** Around 34 million Americans go hungry while edible food is tossed, and low-income families feel it most.



On the Environment

- **More emissions.** Food rotting in landfills gives off methane and drives roughly 8–10% of global greenhouse gases.
- **Wasted resources.** Growing food no one eats wastes about a quarter of the freshwater used for farming, plus land and fuel.



On Wildlife & Other Species

- **Lost habitat.** Clearing forests and land for food we never eat destroys homes for birds, insects, and other animals.
- **Polluted water.** Fertilizer runoff from wasted crops creates ocean “dead zones” where fish and marine life cannot survive.



Solutions at Every Level



Individual

- **Plan and shop smart.** Make a meal plan and a shopping list so you only buy what you will actually use.
- **Store and reuse.** Keep food fresh longer, eat leftovers, and remember “best by” is about quality, not safety.



Local & National

- **Curbside composting.** Cities can collect food scraps and turn them into soil instead of landfill.
- **Donation laws & labels.** National rules and standard date labels help stores send extra food to food banks.



Global

- **Better storage.** Fund refrigeration, roads, and transport so food does not spoil before it reaches people.
- **Shared goals.** Back the UN target to cut food waste in half by 2030 so countries act together.



Evaluating the Top 3 Solutions on the Three E's

The three highest-impact solutions, each weighed against Environment, Economy, and Equity.

Top Solution	Environment	Economy	Equity
Donation laws to rescue surplus food	HIGH Keeps edible food out of landfills and cuts methane.	MED Transport and storage cost money, but donor tax breaks help.	HIGH Feeds people facing hunger right away.
Curbside & community composting	HIGH Cuts landfill methane and rebuilds healthy soil.	MED Startup and pickup costs, but creates jobs and usable compost.	MED Greens neighborhoods, but does not feed people directly.
Smart shopping & clear date labels	HIGH Stops waste at the source, where most of it starts.	HIGH Costs little to run and saves families money.	MED Helps households save, but reaches people unevenly.

HIGH = strong benefit **MED** = some trade-offs